want that data used to generate some other data or a report. So I am told to use an Excel spreadsheet on a network share as part of a process. Typically, I write a shell script. Part of the process might involve using LibreOffice as mentioned above to convert the Excel spreadsheet to a CSV. Perhaps I extract some of the fields from the CSV, use them to interrogate a database, match the output against some other criteria, and finally generate a new CSV.

I can send the output CSV to my customer because Excel accepts CSV as input. I suppose if it were requested, I could use LibreOffice to convert the *.csv* to *.xls* or *.xlsx*, but I have never been asked for that.

I find that scripting is much more powerful than many of the things one might try to do in Excel. The process can be made more automatic, which is particularly advantageous if the process has to be run frequently or regularly. In the latter case, I can invoke my script from *cron*.

But do bear in mind that I am talking about tools. It's always best to find the most appropriate tool for the task. I haven't covered everything, but with this arsenal I can go a long way.

My previous article (Funny Mythness) discussed ways in which you could have Linux in the workplace using virtual machines. In this article, I've suggested ways in which you can move more towards Linux. I've talked about applications that allow you to inter-operate with others who are probably restricted to Microsoft's office applications; and I've discussed tools that allow you to convert from inconvenient formats to those more amenable to manipulation using Linux tools.

In the next article, I will look at UNIX tools and how to unleash their power on files converted with the tools in this article.

**By: Henry Grebler**

The author has spent his days working with computers, mostly for computer manufacturers or software developers. His early computer experiences include relics such as punch cards, paper tape and mag tape. His darkest secret is that he has been paid to do the sorts of things he would have paid money to be allowed to do. Just don't tell any of his employers.

He has used Linux as his personal home desktop since the family got its first PC in 1996. Back then, when the family shared the one PC, it was a dual-boot Windows/Slackware set-up. Now that each member has his/her own computer, Henry somehow survives in a purely Linux world.

He lives in a suburb of Melbourne, Australia.

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## Translatewiki.net

This is a clever project that is in the process of localising MediaWiki. The Translate MediaWiki extension was started in 2006 by *translatewiki.net/wiki/User:Nike* and *translatewiki.net/wiki/User:Gangleri*, and has become very popular for localising MediaWiki, its extensions and a host of other software. MediaWiki itself has been designed with internationalisation and localisation in mind. So it's no wonder that it is available in over 280 languages. Like other Web-based projects, this too requires a contributor to create an account and select preferred languages. Then a project can be selected for localisation, and its various messages can be localised.

Figures 3 and 4 show a typical localisation screenshot. The suggestions from translation memory are shown, along with the percentage of matches, and the blue dots following the number are hyperlinks to the actual translation. The information about the context of the string is shown next, followed by the source, and then an edit box to enter the localised text. This update is saved just like a Wikipedia page. Additional menu buttons allow easy navigation across the messages. Another advantage with this tool is that most updates will go live on the respective language wiki projects of Wikimedia Foundation in 24 hours.

Most Indian-language MediaWiki projects would have been already localised. But occasionally, users may come across pages for which some messages are still in English (Figure 5). Usually, when a project is partially localised, trying to search for the specific message is time-consuming for typical free software. In MediaWiki, it becomes very simple to locate the message_id by appending '*?uselang=qqx*' to the URL of the page. In such a case, MediaWiki software displays message_ids rather than actual English strings (Figure 6). Then you can use the message_id to search Translatewiki.net to directly locate the untranslated message string and translate it (Figure 7).

In this article, we have seen three different Web-based platforms for localisation, which make it easy for anybody to contribute to localisation in their preferred languages. So why not try your hand at it, and share your experience with fellow readers? I will be happy to devote an article exclusively to your feedback and questions.

**For more information**

[1] Launchpad home page: *https://translations.launchpad.net/*
[2] Pootle features: *translate.sourceforge.net/wiki/pootle/features*
[3] LibreOffice translations using Pootle instance: *https://translations.documentfoundation.org/*
[4] Translatewiki.net home page: *translatewiki.net/wiki/Main_Page*

**By: Arjuna Rao Chavala**

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